Hamid Ansari said: 'India's relations with the Rabbani government in the 1992–96 period were of a limited nature and lacked substance.'[24] Nonetheless, with backing from R&AW and influential MEA officials, the decision to support Rabbani and Massoud was taken.

Once the decision had been reached, the MEA started steering Massoud's image in India. According to Aunohita Mojumdar, covering external affairs since 1997: 'All along we were encouraged to support the Northern Alliance'.[25] While there are no signs of specific instructions being given to such effect by the MEA, 'it was generally understood that the Northern Alliance ... were the good guys'.[26] Pranab D. Samanta, former bureau-chief of the *Indian Express* (and currently national affairs editor at the *Economic Times*), agrees that the image of the UF was positive.[27] The focus, however, was on Massoud rather than any other UF commanders. Dostum was most problematic and not least because of his 'opportunism—his men had little tolerance towards minorities even in comparison to the Taliban.[28] However, senior MEA officials had maintained direct links with Dostum throughout, with a pronounced one being the visit of Secretary (East) to Mazar-e-Sharif in October 1996. Nandan Unnikrishnan, an Indian journalist who stayed with Massoud for three days to profile him and shoot a documentary, confirms that India was focused on Massoud. Impressed by the Tajik commander's skills and acumen, Unnikrishan considered him to be a 'visionary'.[29] New Delhi's links with the second rung leadership of the group such as Mohammed Fahim, Abdullah Abdullah, Engineer Arif, Yunus Qanooni, and Amrullah Saleh also proved crucial.

Ironically, while the Taliban or Hekmatyar's fundamentalism was medieval, Massoud's interpretation of religion and statecraft did not exactly provide succour to the women of Afghanistan, who were driven into *purdah*. One of the first statements that Massoud made in 1992, after taking control of Kabul, was his intent to follow the Shariat.[30] X, the R&AW official who was actively engaged in Afghanistan, lays bare India's deliberate but successful attempts to paint the UF as a progressive political and social force. 'Whatever one may say about the Northern Alliance as a force and the Taliban, Massoud was essentially an Islamist', he admits.[31] Though he started wearing jeans and corduroy pants with his *pakol* at some point, that's not how Massoud had started. People very close to the